Lesson 12 material: Reading: The Great Migration and Culture Shock

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

3.1: Reading a Textbook: The Great Migration

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Pre-Reading Activities

The chapter you will be reading from the textbook discusses the migration of African Americans from the South to Northern cities. Answer the questions below to begin thinking about the ideas in the chapter.

- What do you know already about the history of African Americans in the U.S.?
- When you moved to the United States, what **pulled** you here?
- When you moved to the United States, what **pushed** you away from your home country?

Vocabulary Preview

Identify the words below that you already know. Discuss them with your classmates or instructor, or look them up in the dictionary.

- Migration
- Rural
- Historical
- Factor
- Civil War
- Push
- Slavery
- Racism
- Lynching
- Flee/fled
- Vote
- Violence
- Pull

First Reading

When reading a challenging academic text, you will often need to read several times to understand the full meaning. Read through the text one time quickly (skim) to find the main idea. After you read once, write a few notes. What is one thing you remember from your first reading? What is one question you have from your first reading? Your first reading should take only a few minutes; don't try to understand every word, just try to understand the general idea of the text.

The African American "Great Migration": Section One

Between the end of the Civil War (1865) and the beginning of the Great Depression (1929), almost two million African Americans moved from the rural South to look for new opportunities. While some moved west, most of this Great Migration, as the large number of African Americans leaving the South was called, moved to the Northeast and Upper Midwest. More than two-thirds of them moved to the following cities: New York, Chicago, Philadelphia, St. Louis, Detroit, Pittsburgh, Cleveland, and Indianapolis

The African American "Great Migration": Section Two

There are “push” and “pull” factors for any migration (the movement of a large number of people). Even though the Civil War had ended and laws were passed to end slavery and protect the right to vote, African Americans still experienced intense racism. Groups like the Ku Klux Klan caused death threats, violence, and lynchings (murder by hanging). According to researchers at the Tuskegee Institute, there were thirty-five hundred lynchings and other murders committed in the South between 1865 and 1900. For African Americans fleeing this violence, northern and midwestern cities offered an opportunity to escape the dangers of the South.

The African American "Great Migration": Section Three

In addition to this “push” out of the South, African Americans were also “pulled” to the cities by job opportunities and the chance to vote (for men, at least). Many African Americans did not have money to move themselves, but factory owners and other businesses helped pay for their moves. Because of racism, African American workers still had the lower-paying jobs in steel mills, mines, construction, and meat packing. In the railroad industry, they often worked as porters or servants. In other businesses, they worked as janitors, waiters, or cooks. African American women, who faced racism and sexism, often worked as maids and domestic servants. Nevertheless, African Americans earned higher wages in the North than they did for the same jobs in the South, and found housing more easily.

The African American "Great Migration": Section Four

However, life in the city was still difficult. African Americans still experienced the higher cost of living in the North, especially in terms of rent and food. As a result, housing was often overcrowded and dirty. They still experienced racism from landlords, bankers and neighbors. So why move to the North, since the economic problems were similar to those in the South? African Americans moved for non-economic gains. In the North they found greater educational opportunities and personal freedom. Similarly, unlike the South where African Americans often experienced violence, life in larger, crowded cities permitted African Americans to move, work, and speak freely.

Second Reading

Read the chapter a second time. This time, stop and answer the comprehension questions after each section. Take notes.

The African American "Great Migration": Section One

Between the end of the Civil War (1865) and the beginning of the Great Depression (1929), almost two million African Americans moved from the rural South to look for new opportunities. While some moved west, most of this Great Migration, as the large number of African Americans leaving the South was called, moved to the Northeast and Upper Midwest. More than two-thirds of them moved to the following cities: New York, Chicago, Philadelphia, St. Louis, Detroit, Pittsburgh, Cleveland, and Indianapolis

Comprehension Questions

- How many African Americans moved away from the South from 1865 to 1929?
- What is the name of this large historical movement?
- On the map of the U.S. at the end of this chapter, identify the 8 cities mentioned in the paragraph above. Which part of the U.S. is the South?

The African American "Great Migration": Section Two

There are “push” and “pull” factors for any migration (the movement of a large number of people). Even though the Civil War had ended and laws were passed to end slavery and protect the right to vote, African Americans still experienced intense racism. Groups like the Ku Klux Klan caused death threats, violence, and lynchings (murder by hanging). According to researchers at the Tuskegee Institute, there were thirty-five hundred lynchings and other murders committed in the South between 1865 and 1900. For African Americans fleeing this violence, northern and midwestern cities offered an opportunity to escape the dangers of the South.

Comprehension Questions

- What is the "push" factor that caused African Americans to leave the South?
- How many African Americans were murdered in the South between 1865 and 1900?

The African American "Great Migration": Section Three

In addition to this “push” out of the South, African Americans were also “pulled” to the cities by job opportunities and the chance to vote (for men, at least). Many African Americans did not have money to move themselves, but factory owners and other businesses helped pay for their moves. Because of racism, African American workers still had the lower-paying jobs in steel mills, mines, construction, and meat packing. In the railroad industry, they often worked as porters or servants. In other businesses, they worked as janitors, waiters, or cooks. African American women, who faced racism and sexism, often worked as maids and domestic servants. Nevertheless, African Americans earned higher wages in the North than they did for the same jobs in the South, and found housing more easily.

Comprehension Questions

- What are three "pull" factors that caused African Americans to move to Northern cities?

The African American "Great Migration": Section Four

However, life in the city was still difficult. African Americans still experienced the higher cost of living in the North, especially in terms of rent and food. As a result, housing was often overcrowded and dirty. They still experienced racism from landlords, bankers and neighbors. So why move to the North, since the economic problems were similar to those in the South? African Americans moved for non-economic gains. In the North they found greater educational opportunities and personal freedom. Similarly, unlike the South where African Americans often experienced violence, life in larger, crowded cities permitted African Americans to move, work, and speak freely.

Comprehension Questions

- What were two non-economic gains from African Americans who moved to Northern cities?
- Why was life in the city still different for African Americans?

Genre and Reading Strategies

Identify the best answer for each question or fill in the blank.

- The tone of this textbook chapter is_____.
  - Formal
  - Informal
- In order to understand and remember the information in this textbook chapter, I read it _____ times.
- I skimmed this chapter before I read it slowly.
  - Yes
  - No
- Information about the Civil War is in Section _____.
- The definition of the Great Migration is in Section _____.
- When I take notes, it _____.
  - Helps me understand and remember
  - Doesn't help me understand and remember

Summary Writing

One way to understand the remember information from an academic textbook is to write a summary of the chapter after you read it. There are four sections in the chapter. Before you write, re-read the section. Then cover the text and tell your classmates what the section is about. Try to explain it clearly in one sentence. After you have explained the main idea out loud, write one sentence that gives the main idea for each section. Section One is written for you as an example.

Section One

From 1865 to 1929, 2 million African Americans moved from the South to the North.

Discuss or Write

The textbook chapter discusses the "push" and "pull" factors that caused African Americans to migrate from the South to Northern cities. Identify those factors. Are any of those factors similar to your own reasons for immigrating to your current home?

Vocabulary Activity

Match the vocabulary terms in the first list with the matching synonyms or definition in the second list...

1. Migration (n)
2. Rural (adj)
3. Historical (adj)
4. Factor (n)
5. Civil War (proper noun)
6. Slavery (n)
7. Racism (n)
8. Lynching (n)
9. Flee (v)
10. Vote (v)
11. Violence (n)
12. Push (v)
13. Pull (v)

- Related to history; the past
- Murder by hanging without a trial; a form of terrorism
- The movement of a large group of people from one area to another
- Hatred or discrimination toward someone based on race
- Countryside; the opposite of city
- To force away
- To force toward
- A condition where some people own others as property and force them to work
- A circumstance that causes a result
- The war between the North and the South in the U.S., 1861-1865
- To escape; to run away
- Formally choose between people or actions; cast a ballot
- The use of physical force to cause harm

Map of the U.S.

Figure

3.2: Reading: Culture Shock

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Pre-Reading Activities

Discuss or write about these questions with your instructor and classmates.

- How did you feel on the first day you arrived in the U.S.? Did your feelings change over time?
- What are some differences you noticed right away between behavior in your country and behavior in the U.S.?

Vocabulary Preview

Identify which of the following words and phrases you know. Be ready to explain the words to your classmates.

- Taboo
- Cultural
- Norm
- Custom
- Signal
- Gesture
- Culture
- Shock
- Adjust

Sociology in the Real World: Overcoming Culture Shock

During her summer vacation, Caitlin flew from Chicago, Illinois to Madrid, Spain to visit Maria, the friend she met last semester. In the airport, she heard rapid, musical Spanish all around her. It was exciting, but she felt alone and uncomfortable. Maria's mother kissed Caitlin on both cheeks when she greeted her, and Caitlin was surprised. Caitlin was almost asleep by dinner time -- at 10 p.m.! Maria's family sat at the table for hours. They spoke loudly and they argued about politics, a taboo dinner topic in Caitlin's house. They served wine and toasted their honored guest. Caitlin didn't

understand her hosts' facial expressions, and didn't know that she should make the next toast. That night, Caitlin crawled into a strange bed, and she wanted to go home. She felt overwhelmed by the new customs, language, and surroundings.

What Caitlin didn't know was that people use not only spoken words but also subtle cues like gestures and facial expressions, to communicate. Cultural norms accompany even the smallest nonverbal

signals (DuBois 1951). They help people know when to shake hands, where to sit, how to converse, and even when to laugh. We relate to others through shared cultural norms, and ordinarily, we don't even notice them. For this reason, culture shock often happens when traveling to a new country, although it can happen in one's own country, state, or even hometown. Anthropologist Kalervo Oberg (1960) first coined the term "culture shock." In his studies, Oberg found that most people who visited a new country felt excited at first, but over time, they became stressed by interacting with people from a different culture who spoke another language. There was new food, new daily schedules, and new rules of etiquette. Living with this constant stress can make people feel incompetent and nervous. After two weeks in Spain, Caitlin understood that adjusting to a new culture takes time. It can take weeks or months to recover from culture shock, and it can take years to fully adjust to living in a new culture. During her trip, she made new lifelong friends. She learned a lot about Spain, but she also discovered a lot about herself and her own culture.

Glossary

- Taboo (n)- something that is not acceptable to talk about or do
- Toast (v)- to compliment someone, and then take a drink
- Facial expressions (n. phrase)- the way feelings show on someone's face
- Overwhelmed (adj)- to have too many things to deal with
- Custom (n)- a way of behaving that is usual or traditional in a culture
- Subtle cues (n. phrase)- signals that are hard to see
- Gestures (n)- movement of the body
- Cultural norms (n. phrase)- ways of behaving that are normal and acceptable in a culture
- Nonverbal (adj)- without speaking
- Culture shock (n. phrase)- a feeling of confusion, doubt or nervousness caused by being in a new place (such as a foreign country)
- Stress (n), stressed (adj)- tension and worry
- Incompetent (adj)- not having important abilities or skills
- Adjust (v)- to change in order to do better in a new situation

Main Ideas, Details, and Genre

Check your understanding of the text by answering the questions below.

- What is the topic of this text?
  - Visiting Madrid, Spain
  - Caitlin and her travels
  - Culture shock
  - Culture
- A person would probably read this textbook chapter in a _____class.
- How does the chapter explain culture shock?
  - By giving the important history of culture shock

    - By telling a story that shows what culture shock is, and showing why it happens
    - By discussing the advantages and disadvantages of culture shock
    - By advising the reader not to get culture shock
- What are three different cultural norms Caitlin noticed on her first day in Spain?
- How did Caitlin feel by the end of her first day?
- Why do people feel culture shock?
    - They did not learn the language before they moved
    - They like their own culture better than the new culture where they moved
    - People in the new culture are rude and do not accept immigrants
    - Differences in cultural norms are hard to understand, and make people feel stressed, alone, and overwhelmed

Vocabulary Practice

With classmates, write the answers to the questions below. Discuss first, then write your answers.

- What are several examples of taboos in your culture?
- Do people make a toast in your culture? If so, what do they say before they drink?
- What facial expressions do people make when they are happy? angry?
- Give an example of a time you felt overwhelmed.
- What are three customs you follow from your culture?
- Have you experienced culture shock? What did it feel like?
- What are some things people can do to adjust quickly to a new culture?

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Links on the original page

- Introduction to Sociology 2e: https://openstax.org/books/introduction-sociology-2e/pages/3-1-what-is-culture